

## Debating SOCIETY

Contrary to expectations, MPs representing back-of-beyond constituencies have been most vocal

### Shailendra Kumar



**Constituency**  
Chail,  
Uttar Pradesh  
**Party SP**  
**No. of Debates**  
**340**

### Ram Kripal Yadav



**Constituency**  
Patna,  
Bihar  
**Party RJD**  
**No. of Debates**  
**230**

### Bhartruhari Mahtab



**Constituency**  
Cuttack,  
Orissa  
**Party BJD**  
**No. of Debates**  
**227**

### Ramji Lal Suman



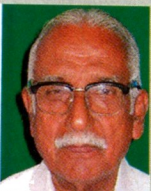
**Constituency**  
Firozabad,  
Uttar Pradesh  
**Party SP**  
**No. of Debates**  
**204**

### Rasa Singh Rawat



**Constituency**  
Ajmer,  
Rajasthan  
**Party BJP**  
**No. of Debates**  
**194**

### Varkala Radhakrishnan



**Constituency**  
Chirayinkil,  
Kerala  
**Party CPI(M)**  
**No. of Debates**  
**188**

has met for only 322 days so far and it is bound to end up as the House which worked the least. Compare this with the first Lok Sabha that met for 677 days when Jawaharlal Nehru was prime minister. Those were days when Parliament was where all relevant information was placed in tune with democratic spirit of governance. The Constitution does not specifically demand that conduct of affairs of state, including foreign policy, must have parliamentary approval. But Nehru saw to it that his government was answerable to Parliament on virtually every aspect of administration.

A little more than four decades after his death, a combination of political compulsions and neo-liberal reflexes of the government have turned Parliamentary debates into

QUITE OFTEN  
PARLIAMENTARY  
DEBATES HAVE BEEN  
TURNED INTO SUDDEN  
DEATH SHOOTOUTS

## Silence of the LIONS

Among the 32 MPs who did not participate even in a single debate were some of the seniormost in the House

### Akshay Pratap Singh



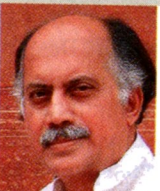
**Constituency**  
Pratapgarh,  
Uttar Pradesh  
**Party SP**  
**Questions asked**  
**0**

### Beni Prasad Verma



**Constituency**  
Kaiserganj,  
Uttar Pradesh  
**Party SP**  
**Questions asked**  
**0**

### Gurudas Kamat



**Constituency**  
Mumbai North  
East, Maharashtra  
**Party Congress**  
**Questions asked**  
**0**

### Moni Kumar Subba



**Constituency**  
Tezpur,  
Assam  
**Party Congress**  
**Questions asked**  
**0**

sudden death shootouts. Last year, 14 important Bills were passed in one day in a piffling 20 minutes. Parliament's shrinking role in governance was eloquently demonstrated on August 26, 2004, when question hour was suspended to rush the Finance Bill through. "This was the result of a backroom agreement between the leaders of parties in the Government and the Opposition," says Bimal Jalan, former RBI governor.

If that wasn't bad enough, too many MPs showed little interest in attending the Lok Sabha. Mamata Banerjee is busy in streetfights in Singur and Nandigram, that after 24 years as an MP and minister, her faith in Parliamentary democracy seems to be on the wane. The attendance register at the lobby of the Lok Sabha shows the MP from Calcutta South attended the House on 52 days, or once every six days. Govinda Arun Ahuja,